



Typography Basics Overview

Brief Overview

This note covering Typography was created from a 6-page PDF ([6-page PDF](#)). It covers font selection, serif vs. sans-serif, **legibility**, **readability**, and practical pairing rules.

Key Points

- Serif vs. sans-serif types
 - Contrast & mood in fonts
 - Legibility vs. readability principles
 - Rules for pairing fonts in design
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Why Typography Matters

Typography is the art of selecting and arranging typefaces to convey mood, authority, and readability. The right font can make a design look professional; the wrong one can even cause miscommunication or safety issues.

- Choosing a **cursive** font for a Valentine's note may seem romantic, but inappropriate fonts can backfire.
 - Proper font selection influences **perception**, **legibility**, and **user experience**.
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Serif Typefaces



History & Mood

Serif typefaces feature small “feet” at the ends of strokes, inspired by ancient marble carvings where perfect right angles were impossible.

- **Mood**: traditional, stable, respectable, authoritative, aged.
- Ideal for **legal letterheads**, **architectural magazines**, and any design that needs a serious tone.



Sub-families & Characteristics

Sub-family	Typical Contrast (thick vs. thin)	Typical Mood	Example
Old Style	Low contrast	Classical, warm	Garamond
Transitional	Moderate contrast	Balanced, historic-modern	Times New Roman
Modern	High contrast	Elegant, upscale	Didot
Slab-Serif	Little to no contrast, blocky serifs	Strong, robust	Rockwell

- The **greater the contrast**, the more *modern* the serif appears.

Visual Contrast (Thick vs. Thin)

The ratio between a letter's thickest and thinnest strokes signals its historical era.

- **Old Style 'o'** → subtle variation.
- **Transitional 'o'** → moderate variation.
- **Modern 'o'** → exaggerated variation.

Sans-Serif Typefaces

Mood & Usage

Sans-serif typefaces lack foot details and use clean right angles, giving a friendly, contemporary feel.

- **Mood:** sensible, simple, straightforward, modern.
- Popular with **startups**, **web interfaces**, and **body text** where readability is key.

Humanist vs. Grotesque

- **Humanist:** high readability, open forms (e.g., Gill Sans, Tahoma, Verdana).
- **Grotesque:** more mechanical, less legible at a glance.

MIT Dashboard Study

- Participants read dashboards in two fonts: **Humanist** vs. **Grotesque**.

- Drivers using Humanist spent **30–40% less time** looking at the display before returning focus to the road.
 - Implication: better legibility can be a matter of **life or death** on fast highways.
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Legibility vs. Readability

Legibility – how easily individual letterforms are distinguished.

Readability – how comfortably blocks of text are read.

Factors Influencing Legibility

- **Open shapes** (e.g., a clear ‘a’ vs. a closed loop).
- **** ample spacing**** between letters.
- **Distinct forms** (e.g., ‘g’ vs. ‘9’).
- **Varying proportions** (different widths for ‘O’ vs. ‘0’).

Factors Influencing Readability

- Consistent line length and leading.
 - Appropriate font weight hierarchy.
 - Balanced contrast for headings vs. body text.
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Practical Font Pairing Rules

- **Limit to two fonts** per design (one for headings, one for body).
 - **Match moods**: pair fonts from the same historical era or with complementary tones.
 - **Create contrast** by mixing **serif** with **sans-serif** (e.g., serif heading + sans-serif body).
 - **Weight contrast**: use bold or black for headings, light or regular for body copy.
 - **Avoid excessive variety**; too many fonts → cluttered, unprofessional look.
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Fonts to Avoid

Certain decorative or overly stylized fonts hinder readability and convey an unprofessional mood.

- When designing a **professional** piece, skip fonts that are overly quirky or difficult to read (the six “bad” examples mentioned in class).
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